

DEEP TIME · FOSSILS

You are standing on a seabed

The ground under Turraburra was the floor of an inland sea long before it was anything else.

During the Cretaceous, a shallow inland sea called the Eromanga Sea spread across most of western Queensland, flooding the region at least five separate times over tens of millions of years. By around 95 million years ago it had withdrawn for good, leaving behind the sand, silt and clay that would become the Winton Formation — one of the richest sources of dinosaur fossils anywhere in Australia.

Stand on the escarpment here and the old shoreline is almost readable in the ground itself. The property holds at least six distinct soil profiles — red clay, pale grey sand, and white sand pale enough to still carry shell fragments — laid down as the coastline here advanced and retreated over deep time. Along its edges, where the sea would have met a fringe of prehistoric mangroves, mud set hard enough to keep footprints. Some of them are still here.

Petrified trees stand in the same ground. One visiting specialist has suggested a scatter of rounded stone nearby may be fossil dinosaur eggs. Nothing has been formally confirmed — the land hasn't finished being read yet.

The best-known resident of this old shoreline lived about a hundred kilometres from here, on the same Iningai and Bidjara Country. In 1963, a grazier named Doug Langdon was mustering cattle near Muttaborra when he found the bones of a seven-metre plant-eater with an unusually large, domed snout. Described in 1981, *Muttaborrasaurus langdoni* is one of the most complete dinosaur skeletons ever found in Australia, and in 2023 it was made Queensland's official fossil emblem.

The record is still growing. In 2026, a palaeontologist relocated the original 1963 site and recovered another 1,300 bone fragments from the ground — enough to show the dinosaur likely carried teeth at the very tip of its snout, something no one had expected of it.

The same sea that shaped this Country also carried plesiosaurs — long-necked marine reptiles up to ten metres long. Some of the most complete examples found anywhere in the world have turned up on outback cattle properties not far from here, discovered by graziers rather than expeditions. Whatever swam past this shoreline is still, mostly, underground.

The escarpment above Marra Wonga is younger than all of it. Before anyone marked the wall, this ground was already a hundred million years into its own story.